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Thomas

The loyal, blunt disciple whose doubt ended in the Gospel's highest confession.

Thomas is often called "Doubting Thomas," but that nickname is not in the Bible, and it tells only part of his story. John's Gospel shows him as a man of courage and honesty. When Jesus decided to return to Judea, where enemies wanted him dead, Thomas said, "Let us also go, that we may die with him." When Jesus spoke of the way to the Father, Thomas admitted he did not understand. And when the others said they had seen the risen Lord, Thomas refused to believe without seeing the wounds. A week later Jesus met him and invited him to touch. Thomas answered with the fullest confession of faith in the Gospels: "My Lord and my God."

At a glance

Name	Aramaic <i>Thoma</i> , "twin"; in Greek Didymus, also "twin" (John 11:16)
Family	Not named; the twin is never identified
Among the Twelve	Matthew 10:3; Mark 3:18; Luke 6:15; Acts 1:13
Main passages	John 11:16; 14:5–6; 20:24–29; 21:2
Known for	Courage, blunt questions and the confession "My Lord and my God"
Nickname	"Doubting Thomas" is a later phrase, not biblical
Later life	Not recorded in Scripture; see Tradition on page 4

"And Thomas answered and said unto him, My Lord and my God."

John 20:28, KJV

The life of Thomas

Dates are approximate (AD). The crucifixion is dated AD 30 or AD 33; this study uses c. AD 30. Only John tells stories about Thomas; the other Gospels list him.

- c. AD 28

Galilee

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Chosen as an apostle

Jesus names the Twelve, and Thomas is among them. Nothing else is known of his life before this. *Luke 6:13–16*
- c. AD 30

Beyond Jordan

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Ready to die with Jesus

When Jesus decides to go back to Judea after Lazarus dies, the disciples warn him of danger. Thomas urges them to go and die with him. *John 11:7–16*
- c. AD 30

The last supper

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Asks the way

Jesus says the disciples know the way. Thomas answers that they do not even know where he is going. Jesus replies, "I am the way, the truth, and the life." *John 14:4–6*
- c. AD 30

Easter evening

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Absent and unconvinced

Thomas is not with the others when Jesus appears. He says he will not believe unless he sees and touches the nail prints and the wound in Jesus' side. *John 20:19–25*
- c. AD 30

Eight days later

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Sees and believes

Jesus appears again with Thomas present and invites him to touch his wounds. Thomas confesses, "My Lord and my God." *John 20:26–29*
- c. AD 30

Sea of Tiberias

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Goes fishing

Thomas is among the seven who meet the risen Jesus by the sea. *John 21:1–2*

Group notes

Key activities

Scripture never says whether Thomas actually touched Jesus' wounds. Jesus invited him to, but John records only his confession.

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- 1 Followed as one of the Twelve.** He was chosen and named in every list of apostles. *Matthew 10:3; Acts 1:13*
 - 2 Spoke with courage.** He said, "Let us also go, that we may die with him." *John 11:16*
 - 3 Asked an honest question.** He said, "Lord, we know not whither thou goest; and how can we know the way?" *John 14:5*
 - 4 Demanded evidence.** Unless he could see "the print of the nails" and touch the wounds, he said, "I will not believe." *John 20:25*
 - 5 Confessed Jesus as Lord and God.** Faced with the risen Christ, he gave the Gospel's clearest confession. *John 20:28*
 - 6 Received a blessing for others.** Jesus told him, "blessed are they that have not seen, and yet have believed." *John 20:29*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Thomas.

Old Testament

Echo: Judges 6:36–40	Gideon asks God for signs before he will believe
Echo: Psalm 35:23	"My God and my Lord," the titles Thomas gives Jesus

New Testament

John 11:16; 14:5; 20:24–29; 21:2	Thomas's words and appearances
Matthew 10:3; Mark 3:18; Luke 6:15; Acts 1:13	Listed among the Twelve
John 20:30–31	John writes "that ye might believe" right after Thomas's story
1 Peter 1:8	Believers who love Jesus without having seen him
Tradition	Early writers say Parthia; the Saint Thomas Christians of India say he died near Chennai

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Thomas say he needed before he would believe, and what did Jesus offer him (John 20:25–27)?
2. *Understand:* Jesus blessed "they that have not seen, and yet have believed." What does that mean for readers of John's Gospel today?
3. *Apply:* Thomas was honest about his questions. What doubt or question could you bring into the open with God or with your group?
4. *Apply:* Thomas missed the first meeting with the risen Lord. How can you keep from missing your gathering this week?